

A syntactic approach to two second position effects in Basque*

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1 Introduction

Focus: A puzzle in Basque concerns the relationship between two second-position effects whereby the verb must be non-initial in two different-sized domains (Arregi and Nevins, 2012; Kiparsky, 2017).

- (1) **The higher constraint:** The finite verb cannot abut the left edge of the clause.
*[_{CLAUSE} V_{FINITE} ...]
- (2) **The lower constraint:** The verb root cannot abut the left edge of a finite verb.
*[_{MWORD} V_{ROOT} ...]

Main claims:

- i. Contra Laka (1993), Arregi and Nevins (2012), Kiparsky (2017) and Haddican (2018), we claim both of these reflect ordinary syntactic EPP effects, i.e. a property of a head requiring (re-)merge of an XP in syntax (Roberts, 2004; Joutteau, 2008; Holmberg, 2015; Van Urk and Richards, 2015; Bošković, 2024), as in (3).
 - ii. The two second-position effects resemble EPP effects in Mainland Scandinavian on “T” (subject EPP effects) and “C” (V2). Feature inheritance cannot furnish a unified account of the two effects, unlike in Biberauer and Roberts’s (2010) account. Rather, we propose that the EPP feature is shared under agreement between the loci of the two effects.
- (3) **Second position patterns as an EPP effect**
[_{HP} XP H_[EPP] ...]

Outline:

- §1. Introduction
- §2. The lower constraint
- §3. The relationship between the higher and lower constraints
- §4. Conclusion

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2 The lower constraint

2.1 Overview

The basic morpheme order of Basque auxiliaries is traditionally described as following the template in (4) (Cheng and Demirdache, 1993; Laka, 1993; Albizu, 1997, 2002; Arregi and Nevins, 2012). Here, “Abs(olutive)”, “Dat(ive)” and “Erg(ative)” refer to person morphemes. (This sets aside certain absolutive number morphemes, allocutive clitics and modal particles.)

(4) **Abs/Erg/Expl-Root-Dat-Erg-T**

(5) ***Basque clitic cheat sheet***

- i. With some important exceptions (see below), all person morphemes on finite verb forms are clitics (Laka, 1993; Arregi and Nevins, 2012).
- ii. Clitics appear only and always in finite contexts, doubling a (possibly silent) DP.
- iii. There are no third person clitics.

The complementary distribution of Abs. & Erg. clitics and expletive morphemes in (4) is commonly taken to reflect a second-position restriction, descriptively as in (2). Potential violations of (6) are those without a 1/2 Abs. argument (7b).

(6) ***The lower pattern:*** The root of the finite verb cannot abut the left edge of the word.

*[_{MWORD} ROOT_V ...

(7) ***Contexts without a 1/2 Abs. clitic need repair***¹

- a. Ikusi **n**-a-u-zu.
see **1SG.ABS-F-ROOT-2SG.ERG**
‘You have seen me.’
- b. *Ikusi __-(a)-u-zu.
see __-F-ROOT-2SG.ERG
‘You have seen it.’

Two different repair strategies apply in such contexts: (i) *ergative displacement* (Albizu, 2002; Laka, 1993; Albizu and Eguren, 2000; Fernández and Albizu, 2000; Rezac, 2006, 2008; Béjar and Rezac, 2009; Arregi and Nevins, 2012; Haddican, 2018); and (ii) *expletive insertion* (Laka, 1993; Albizu, 1997, 2002; Arregi and Nevins, 2012; Haddican, 2018).

(8) ***Repair strategy 1: Ergative displacement (past & irrealis only)***

- a. Ikusi z-int-u-**da**-(e)n.
see **2SG.ABS-F-ROOT-1SG.ERG-PST**
‘I saw you.’
- b. Ikusi **n**-u-en.
see **1SG.ERG-ROOT-PST**
‘I saw it.’

In contexts lacking both 3.ERG and 3.ABS (and in present tense lacking just 3.ABS),

¹The category of “F” is discussed later.

one of five expletive morphemes *d-*, *z-*, *l-*, *b-* or $\emptyset$, appear initially.

(9) ***Repair strategy 2: Expletive insertion***

- a. Egin **d**-u.
do **EXPL-ROOT**
'He/she/it/they_{sg} has/have done it.' [Present]
- b. Egin **z**-u-en.
do **EXPL-ROOT-PST**
'He/she/it/they_{sg} did it.' [Past]
- c. Egin-go **l**-u-ke.
do-IRR **EXPL-ROOT-MOD**
'He/she/it/they_{sg} would do it.' [Irrealis]
- d. Egin $\emptyset$ -zai-o.
do **EXPL-ROOT-3SG.DAT**
'It has been done to him/her/it/them_{sg}.' [Dat. experiencer]
- e. Goi-an **b**-e-go.
high-on **EXPL-F-COP**
'Rest in peace' (lit.: be on high) [Imperative]

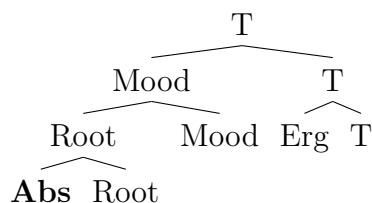
2.2 Previous models

All previous models I'm aware of including Laka (1993), Albizu and Eguren (2000), Arregi and Nevins (2012), Kiparsky (2017) and Haddican (2018) posit some post-syntactic operations.

2.2.1 Laka (1993)

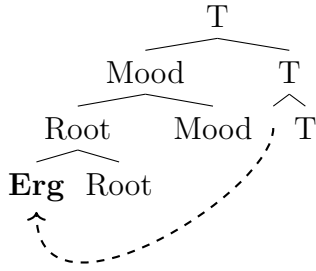
Laka (1993) models both of these repair operations as rules that apply in the mapping from S-structure to PF. Laka proposes that in the unmarked case, containing an absolutive clitic, the absolutive adjoins lowest among person clitics, to the verbal root, and ergative clitics adjoin to T.

(10) ***Laka's (1993) structure for default 1/2 Abs. contexts***



Laka takes ergative displacement to be a case of “sub-atomic” clitic movement, i.e. a movement process moving a clitic within a complex head formed by syntactic adjunction, as in (11).

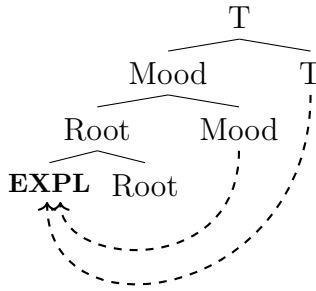
(11) *Laka's (1993) model of ergative displacement*



Laka proposes that expletive insertion, like ergative displacement, applies in the mapping from S-structure to phonetic form, to provide phonetic content to an empty position pursuant to (12).

(12) An F-head assigns a marker to an empty absolutive position iff it [the F-head] is the head of the structure.

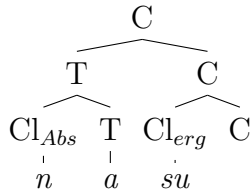
(13) *Absolutive marker assignment in Laka's (1993) model*



2.2.2 Arregi & Nevins (2012)

(14) *Abs & Erg clitic adjunction in Arregi and Nevins's (2012) model*

- a. Ikusi n-a-su.
 seen ABS.1SG-ROOT-2SG.ERG
 'You have seen me.'
 (Arregi and Nevins, 2012, 34-36)
- b.



Both ergative displacement and expletive insertion are motivated by (15). Ergative displacement is an operation on a linearized string.

(15) *T-Noninitiality*

The terminal T cannot be leftmost within $T^{0\max}$.

(16) ***Ergative metathesis in Arregi and Nevins’s (2012) model***

Egin n- eu- _ n.
 $\uparrow$ $\downarrow$
do 1SG.ERG ROOT C.PST
‘I did it.’

(Adapted from Arregi and Nevins (2012))

Expletive insertion is produced by the elsewhere rule in (17).

(17) ***L-Support***

- a. Structural description: $[T^{0\max} T$
- b. Structural change: Insert L to the immediate left of T.
(Arregi and Nevins, 2012, 286)

2.2.3 Albizu & Eguren (2000) and Kiparsky (2017)

Similar in spirit to Arregi and Nevins’s (2012) analysis are Optimality Theoretic constraints by Albizu and Eguren (2000) and Kiparsky (2017). Kiparsky’s (2017) lexicalist OT model includes an undominated constraint penalizing T-initial forms in a word as in (18). We return to Kiparsky’s (2017) model later.

(18) T^0 (the auxiliary morpheme) can’t be initial in its word.

Albizu and Eguren (2000) follow Noyer (1992) in taking the initial position to be a “position of exponence”—a morphological position that must be obligatorily realized. The relevant constraint in their model is an undominated *obligatory prefix* constraint, (19).

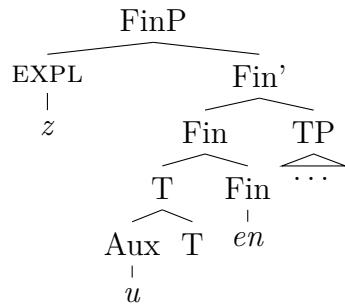
(19) OBPREF: Basque finite verbal forms must have a prefix.

2.2.4 Haddican (2018)

Haddican (2018) takes the left edge to be a spec position, FinP, as in (20).

(20) ***Post-syntactic expletive insertion in Haddican’s (2018) model***

- a. Egin z-u-en.
do EXPL-ROOT-PST
‘He/she/it/they_{sg} did it.’
- b.



Haddican’s (2018) approach takes expletives to reflect a post-syntactic repair inserting an expletive in the first position, whose head expones the *-en* morpheme of past tense

contexts. Ergative displacement reflects syntactic movement to the same spec position targeted by expletive insertion.

- (21) If spec, FinP is not filled at spell-out, insert an expletive morpheme.

2.3 Against a post-syntactic account

A generalization missed by all of these approaches that is expressed naturally on a syntactic EPP approach is that the first position element must be a person morpheme or expletive, a fact discussed in much of the cyclic agree literature (Béjar and Rezac, 2009). (See also Coon and Keine (2021) and Tamar-Mattis (2026).)

- (22) *First position elements are person or expletive morphemes*

- a. Ikusi **n**-a-u-zu.
see **1SG.ABS**-F-ROOT-2SG.ERG
'You have seen me.' [Abs. clitic]
- b. Ikusi **n**-u-en.
see **1SG.ERG**-ROOT-C.PST
'I saw it.' [Erg. displacement]
- c. Gusta-tzen **n**-a-u.
like-IMPERF **1SG.DAT**-F-ROOT
'I like it.' [Dat. displacement]
- d. Joan **y**-u-(**k/n**)-en.
go **2SG.FAM**-ROOT-2SG.FAM-FIN
'He/she/it went.' [Alloc. displacement]
- e. Ikusi **d**-u.
see **EXPL**-ROOT
'He/she/it/they_{sg} has/have seen it.' [Expl. insertion]

In addition, much of the literature pursuing PF approaches to the EPP has focused on the fact that candidate edge elements cannot be silent (Holmberg, 2000; Landau, 2007; Sigurðsson, 2010; McFadden and Sundaresan, 2018).

- (23) a. Yameris hikes.
b. **pro* hikes.

Several kinds of silent elements can satisfy the lower constraint. One is the 2sg.informal person clitic in southern dialects (orthographically <h>).

- (24) Aleti-zale peto-pettoa [**h**-aiz.]
Athletic-fan through-and-through **2SG.FAM**-ROOT
'You are an Athletic fan through and through.'

A second is the silent expletive of dative intransitives:

- (25) Gusta-tzen [**∅**-za-i-t].
like-IMPERF **EXPL**-ROOT-P-1SG.DAT
'I like it.'

And in western dialects, past tense expletives can be silent.

- (26) Ikusi [$\emptyset$ -ebe-n]
 see **EXPL**-ROOT-PST
 ‘She saw it.’ [Western dialects]

2.4 Initial position is a high position

Again, our analysis of the lower constraint is as a syntactic EPP effect with an XP obligatorily occupying a given spec position.

- (27) *Second position patterns as an EPP effect*
 [_{HP} XP H_[EPP] ...]

Here we defend this position against claims taking the left edge to be the most deeply embedded terminal (Laka, 1993; Arregi and Nevins, 2012; Kramer, 2014; Siebecker, 2015).

2.4.1 Abs clitics do not adjoin to/incorporate into a low probe

If absolutive arguments are probed by *v*/Voice (Rezac, 2008), one might expect the landing site of absolutive clitics to be these same heads (Kramer, 2014; Siebecker, 2015). But, as Arregi and Nevins (2012) note, for the absolutive clitic to combine with the rest of finite verb (in T or higher), this morpheme will then have to undergo decidedly non-local head movement, raising across aspectual morphemes and modals (28), and out of non-finite embeddings (29).

- (28) *Absolutive clitics raise across aspect and modal heads*

- a. [_v Ikus]-**ten** **n**-a-u-te
 see-IMPERF 1SG-F-ROOT-PL.ERG
 ‘They see me.’
 b. [_v Ikusi] **nahi** **n**-a-u-te
 see want 1SG-F-ROOT-PL.ERG
 ‘They want to see me.’

- (29) *Absolutive clitics raise out of non-finite constituents*

Saiatu-ko **z**-a-it-u-gu [jend-artean aurki-tze-n]
 try-FUT **2SG**-F-ABS.PL-ROOT-1PL.ERG people-among find-N-LOC
 ‘We will try to find you among the people.’
 (Etxepare, 2006)

Finally, the fact that the allocutive clitic can occupy the V_{finite} -initial position indicates that this slot is targetable by allocutive clitic movement. If this movement is upward, then the initial slot must be above the position where allocutive clitics are introduced—what’s typically taken to be a fairly high position.

(30) ***Allocutive displacement in Oiartzun Basque***

- a. Joan d-u-(k/n).
go 2SG.FAM-ROOT
'He/she/it has gone.' [Allocutive clitic]
 - b. Joan y-u-(k/n)-en.
go 2SG.FAM-ROOT-2SG.FAM-FIN
'He/she/it went.' [Multiple allocutive clitics]
 - c. Joan y-az.
go 2SG.FAM-ROOT
'You have gone.' [Thematic 2SG clitic]
- (Yrizar, 1992; Fraile and Fraile, 1996)

These facts suggest that absolutive clitics are “C-oriented”, moving to left-peripheral rather than TP-internal positions (Uriagereka, 1995a,b; Bošković, 2001; Roberts and Cardinaletti, 2002; Roberts, 2010).

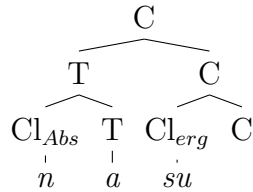
2.4.2 Evidence from allomorphy

In addition, an analysis that would seem to cut against (27) comes from Arregi and Nevins’s (2012) analysis of tense morphemes and their interaction with force-marking complementizers. Arregi and Nevins (2012) take the root to be the exponent of a T head (via late insertion rules), and initial position to be the most deeply embedded terminal.

(31) ***Abs & Erg clitic adjunction in Arregi and Nevins’s (2012) model***

- a. Ikusi n-a-su.
seen ABS.1SG-ROOT-2SG.ERG
'You have seen me.'
(Arregi and Nevins, 2012, 34-36)

b.



This suggests a need to rethink the status of the final *-en* morpheme in past tense contexts like (32), commonly taken to be a T morpheme (Laka, 1993; Albizu, 2002).

(32) ***Final -en in past tense contexts***

- Egin z-u-en.
do EXPL/ROOT-?
'She did it.'

Arregi and Nevins (2012) propose that the *-en* form in (32) is not a tense head, but rather a tense-specified complementizer akin to the past complementizers of Irish as described by McCloskey (2000).

(33) **Irish past tense C**

Deir siad **gur** ghoid na síogaí í.
 say they C stole the fairies her
 ‘They say the fairies stole her away.’
 (McCloskey, 2001)

Arregi and Nevins (2012) note that the *-en* morepheme in past tense contexts like (32) are in complementary distribution with “true” force-marking complementizers including *-ela* appearing in embedded declaratives and *-en* appearing in embedded interrogatives and operator movement constructions including temporal adjunct clauses and relative clauses, as in (34) and (35). This would seem to support their analysis of the left tense-marked forms as corresponding a more deeply embedded true T head.

(34) **Declarative C**

Uste dut [etorri-ko g-in-e-(*en-)(e)la].
 think AUX-1SG come-FUT 1PL.ABS-F-ROOT-PST-C
 ‘I think we were going to come.’

(35) **Interrogative C**

Ez dakit [nork irabazi z-u-(*en-)en].
 NEG KNOW-1SG who win-FUT EXPL-AUX-PST-C
 ‘I don’t know who will win.’

But this analysis makes some mispredictions about allomorphic conditioning of 1SG & 2SG clitics. Specifically, Table 1 shows that first and second person familiar clitics vary in form depending on whether they abut the left edge of the morphological word, the right edge, or neither. These alternations are illustrated for first and second person forms in (36) and (37), respectively.

<i>Person*number*gender</i>	<i>Free pronoun</i>	<i>Finite verb-internal forms</i>		
		<i>L edge</i>	<i>Internal</i>	<i>R edge</i>
1SG	ni	n-	-da-	-t
2SG.FAM.MASC	hi	h-	-a-	-k
2SG.FAM.FEM	ni	h-	-na-	-n

Table 1: Positional allomorphy in 1sg and 2sg forms

Importantly, the initial forms (i) show the same initial segment as the free pronominal forms (*ni*, *hi*); and (ii) like free pronominals are syncretic for gender.

(36) **Edge-sensitive allomorphy for 1SG forms**

- a. Etorri [**n**-a-iz].
 come **1SG.ABS**-F-ROOT
 ‘I have come’ [L edge form]
- b. Eman [d-i-**da**-zu].
 give EXPL-ROOT-**1SG.DAT**-2SG.FORM
 ‘You have given me it.’ [Internal form]
- c. Eman [d-i-**t**].
 give EXPL-ROOT-**1SG.DAT**
 ‘She has given me it.’ [R edge form]

- (37) **Edge-sensitive allomorphy for 2SG.FAM forms**
- a. Etorri [h-a-iz].
come 2SG.ABS-F-ROOT
'You have come.' [L edge form]
 - b. Eman [d-i-a/na-gu].
give EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC/FEM-1PL
'We have given you it.' [Internal form]
 - c. Eman [d-i-k/n].
give EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC/FEM
'She has given you it.' [R edge form]
- (38) **These forms vary by position rather than by case!**
- a. Ikusi n-u-en.
see 1SG.ERG-ROOT-C.PST
'I saw it.' [Ergative displacement]
 - b. Gusta-tzen n-a-u.
like-IMPERF 1SG.DAT-F-ROOT
'I like it.' [Dative displacement]
 - c. Eman [d-i-a/na-gu].
give EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC/FEM-1PL
'We have given you it.' [Internal form (dative)]
 - d. Egin [d-u-k/n].
do EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC/FEM
'You have done it.' [R edge form (ergative)]

Importantly, in central dialects, force marking complementizers *-ela* and *-en* differ from the *-en* of past tense contexts in determining the edge form. The data in (37) and (38) are unexpected from the perspective of Arregi and Nevins's (2012) model which takes the *-en* of past tense contexts like (37c) and (38c) to be variants of C in complementary distribution with the Force-marking heads in (37a,b) and (38a,b).

- (39) **Allomorphic conditioning of 1SG clitic by AUX-final morpheme**
- a. Ba-dirudi [eman [d-i-(t/*da)-(e)la]].
BA-seems give EXPL-ROOT-1SG.DAT-C
'It seems she has given me it.' [Force-marking *-ela* → R edge form]
 - b. Ez dakit [eman [d-i-(t/*da)-(e)n]].
NEG know.1SG give EXPL-ROOT-1SG.DAT-C
'I don't know if she has given me it.' [Force-marking *-en* → R edge form]
 - c. Eman z-i-(t/*da)-(e)n.
do EXPL-ROOT-1SG.DAT-PST
'You gave me it.' [Past *-en* → internal form]
- (40) **Allomorphic conditioning of 2SG.FAM clitic by AUX-final morpheme**
- a. Ba-dirudi [etorri [d-u-(k/*a)-(e)la]].
BA-seems come EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC-C
'It seems she has come.' [Force-marking *-ela* → R edge form]
 - b. Ez dakit [etorri [d-u-(k/*a)-(e)n]].
NEG know.1SG come EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC-C

- ‘I don’t know if she has come.’ [Force-marking *-en* → R edge form]
 c. Egin z-i-(***k/a**)-(e)**n**.
 do EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC-PST
 ‘She did it.’ [Past *-en* → internal form]

These allomorphy effects suggests that force-marking *-en/-ela* delimit a higher domain than past tense *-en*, suggesting the past tense *-en* is not a C element and undercutting an argument by Arregi and Nevins (2012) for taking the right side to be the higher structure.

- (41) [[V_{FINITE} Past *-en*] Force-marking *-en/-ela*]

In addition, we note that the EPP approach in (27) provides a natural account of the fact that the first position forms in Table 1 behave like free pronouns but internal and R edge forms do not: because the left edge forms, like free pronouns, pronouns in a specifier position. The internal and right edge forms we then take to be exponents of agreement.

Nevertheless, Arregi and Nevins’s (2012) proposal that auxiliaries consist of two heads with tense features—T and a tense-marked C—helps model the fact that morphemes at both the left and right edge of the finite verb co-vary with tense.

- (42) *Morphemes covary with tense at both edges of the finite V*


- (43) *Contexts with initial morphemes*

- a. Ikusi **d-u**.
 see EXPL-ROOT
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} has seen him/her/it/them_{sg}’
 b. Ikusi **z-u-en**.
 see EXPL-ROOT-PST
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} saw him/her/it/them_{sg}’

- (44) *Contexts with absolutive clitics*

- a. Ikusi **n-a-u**.
 see 1SG-F-ROOT
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} has seen me.’
 b. Ikusi **n-in(d)-u-en**.
 see 1SG-F-ROOT-PST
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} saw me.’

With an expletive, this form is again *-a-* in the present tense, but *-e(n)-* in the past.

- (45) *Tense conditioning of F in the presence of expletives*

- a. Mikel **d-a-tor**.
 Mikel EXPL-F-COME
 ‘Mikel comes.’ [Present]
 b. Mikel **z-e-tor(r)-en**.
 Come 1SG-F-COME-PST
 ‘Mikel was coming.’ [Past]

Importantly, ergative clitics behave quite differently.

- (46) ***Tense conditioning of F in ergative displacement contexts***
- a. Ikusi **n-ind**-u-en.
 see **1SG-F-ROOT-PST**
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} saw me.’ [F with 1SG.ABS]
 - b. Ikusi **n-u-en**.(*n-ind-u-en)
 see **1SG.ERG-ROOT-PST**
 ‘I saw it.’ [No overt F with 1SG.ERG]
 - c. Ikusi **g-en-u-en**.
 see **1PL.ERG-F-ROOT-PST**
 ‘We saw him/her/it/them_{sg}’ [F with 1PL.ERG]

These forms have been analyzed in several different ways in the literature (Gómez, 1994; Fernández and Albizu, 2000; Béjar and Rezac, 2009). Laka (1993) and Arregi and Nevins (2012) modeled the variation between *-a-* and *-in(d)-* in (46) as part of the exponence of a T head, as in (47).

- (47) n-au
 1SG.ABS-T

But this misses the generalization that the *-a-* and *-in(d)-* strings recur across roots.

- (48) ***Strings -a-/in(d)- covary with tense in ‘be’-root contexts***
- a. Etorri n-**a**-iz.
 Come 1SG-F-ROOT
 ‘I have come.’ [Present]
 - b. Etorri n-**in(t)**-z-en.
 Come 1SG-F-ROOT-PST
 ‘I came.’ [Past]
- (49) ***Strings -a-/in(d)- covary with tense in ‘walk’-root contexts***
- a. n-**a**-bil.
 1SG-F-walk
 ‘I walk.’ [Present]
 - b. n-**en**-bil-en.
 1SG-F-walk-PST
 ‘I walked.’ [Past]

We therefore take F to be a separate morpheme, and consider its identity in the analysis below.

2.5 A syntactic account

We adopt Arregi and Nevins’s (2012) proposal that tense marking at both edges of the finite verb form must reflect the presence of both a T head and a tense-marked C-field head. The fact that one expletive (*b-*) co-varies with imperative force suggests, contra Arregi and Nevins (2012), that it is the *left* edge that corresponds to higher material—a tense marked Fin head, whose EPP property requires (re-)merge in syntax.

- (50) [_{FinP} **XP** Fin_[EPP] [_{TP} V_{FINITE}]]

Summary of the analysis of the lower constraint:

- i. **Clitic structure:** Person clitics are DPs, merged with their doubled associates in a big KP structure (Uriagereka, 1995a; Nevins, 2011), and raise as XPs (Cardinaletti and Starke, 1999; Sportiche, 2005; Săvescu-Ciucivara, 2009). We assume they target the position of their phi-probes (Roberts, 2010).

$$(51) \quad [_{KP} \text{ DP } [_{K'} \text{ K DP }]]$$

- ii. **Agreement, case and clitic movement:** T is the probe for ergative arguments (Rezac, 2008). Ergative clitics target T. Voice/*v* is not a participant probe (Arregi and Nevins, 2012). Fin, a speech act anchor, probes for speech act participants, i.e. first and second-person clitics (Uriagereka, 1995a; Sigurðsson, 2010). Abs clitics trigger agreement on Fin (see below) (Arregi and Nevins, 2012).

$$[_{FinP} \text{ XP Fin}_{[EPP, PART]} [_{TP} \text{ T}_{\phi} \dots [_{DERG} \dots \text{D}_{ABS}]]]$$

- iii. **Tense condition on ergative displacement:** Covariation in tense features between T and Fin suggests a process of feature sharing, which we take to be a [*uT*] feature on T. Through this process of feature sharing, the valued participant features of T are copied to Fin. In this way, the ergative clitic is effectively probed by Fin, and moves to Fin to satisfy its EPP requirement.

(52) **Tense matching between Fin and T**

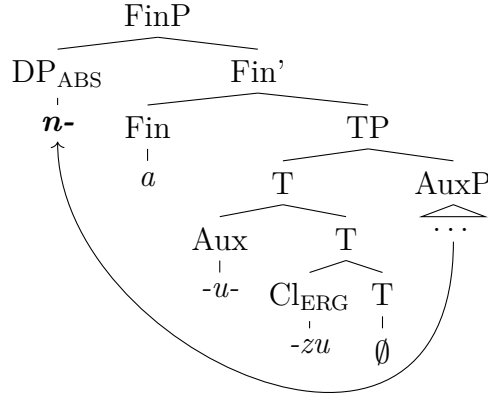
$$[_{Fin_{uT}} [\dots \text{T}_{\phi}]]$$

- iv. **Expletives:** Elsewhere, an expletive is merged in FinP. We take expletives *d-*, *z-*, *l-*, all coronals, to be allomorphs of a single expletive element ([+coronal]) with voice and manner conditioned by its Fin host. It satisfies the [*uPART*] feature of Fin, much as English *there* matches person features on T (Chomsky, 2001).
- v. **Phi agreement on Fin:** We take Fin to be the “F” morpheme. The fact that exponence of this head is sensitive to the number and case of the clitic to its left—that is, absolutive vs. ergative—supports phi probing of clitics by Fin. Again, in the present tense, and in the past tense with singular ergative clitics, there is no overt Fin (46b). We propose that this reflects the fact that ergative clitics cannot value the participant feature on Fin because they have already been probed by T. Hence, absolutive clitics and expletives which have a [PART] feature will trigger agreement on Fin, but singular ergative clitics will not.

Here’s how these assumptions express the three core patterns. An absolutive clitic when present, will raise to FinP, where it triggers participant agreement on Fin (Arregi and Nevins, 2012). (The representation of the ergative clitic here is a fig leaf for unresolved questions about non-initial clitics.)

(53) ***Absolute clitic contexts***

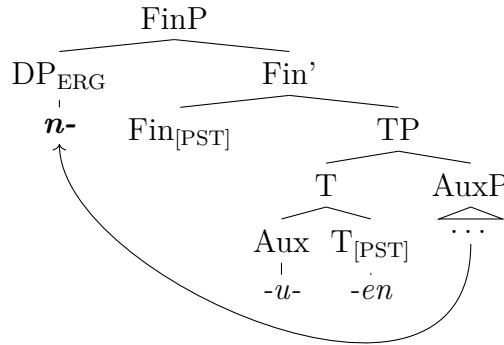
- a. Ikusi **n**-a-u-zu.
 seen 1SG.ABS-FIN-ROOT-2SG.ERG
 ‘You have seen me.’
 b.



Ergative clitics ordinarily target their phi probe, T (Laka, 1993; Rezac, 2008). Let us assume that via Fin’s agreement with T, it probe for external arguments, and thereby attract ergative clitics.²

(54) ***Ergative displacement***

- a. Ikusi **n**-u-en.
 see 1SG.ERG-ROOT-PST
 ‘I saw he/she/it/them_{sg}.’
 b.

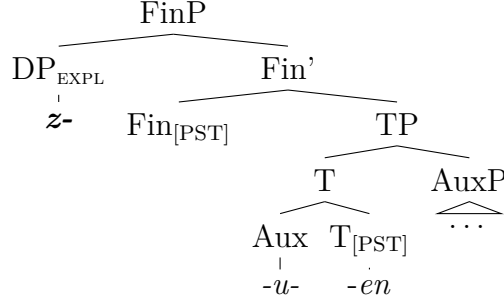


When no clitics are available to raise to FinP, an expletive [+ coronal] is merged.

²There’s an important unresolved issue here. If the internal and edge forms in Table 1 expone agreement, then what becomes of the clitics targeting these positions that presumably trigger agreement? One possibility is a requirement that the clitic delete in the presence of a non-silent head, following Collins and Kayne’s (2023) No Crowding Condition. Another possibility, given that these non-clitic forms only appear for first and second person singular forms is incorporation under agreement following Roberts (2010).

(55) **Expletive contexts**

- a. Ikusi **z-u-en**.
 see EXPL-ROOT-PST
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} saw he/she/it/them_{sg}.’
- b.



3 The relationship between the higher and lower constraints

We now turn to the “higher constraint”. The basic constraint, schematized in (56), is that, in the general case, the finite verb cannot appear adjacent to the left edge of the clause (Ortiz de Urbina, 1989; Laka, 1990; Elordieta, 2001; Elordieta and Jouitteau, 2010; Duguine and Kaiser, 2025).

- (56) **The higher constraint:** The finite verb cannot be at the left edge of the clause.
 $*[_{\text{CLAUSE}} V_{\text{FINITE}}$

3.1 Overview of the higher constraint

(57) **Higher constraint effects**

- a. Mikel dator.
 Mikel comes
 ‘Mikel comes.’ [Subject initial unaccusative]
- b. *Dator.
 comes
 ‘He/she/it/they_{sg} come(s).’ [Unaccusative with null subject]
- c. *Dator Mikel./?
 comes Mikel.
 ‘Mikel comes./Does Mikel come?’ [Unaccusative with inversion]
- d. GAUR dator Mikel.
 today comes Mikel
 ‘Mikel comes TODAY.’ [Focus to the left of finite V]
- e. Ez dator Mikel.
 NEG comes Mikel
 ‘Mikel doesn’t come.’ [Negation to the left of finite V]
- f. Etorr-i da Mikel.
 come-PERF AUX Mikel
 ‘Mikel has come.’ [Periphrastic V to the left of finite aux]

In contexts where the constraint in (1) would otherwise be violated, the structure can

be rescued by insertion of an expletive *ba-* morpheme (Ortiz de Urbina, 1989; Laka, 1990; Elordieta and Haddican, 2018). We illustrate this in (58a,b), showing rescuing of (57b,c) by insertion of *ba-*.

(58) ***Ba-insertion rescues V-initial strings***

- a. *(**Ba-**)dator.
EXPL-comes
'He/she/it/they_{sg}. come(s).'
 - b. *(**Ba-**)dator Mikel./?
EXPL-comes Mikel.
'Mikel comes./Does Mikel come?'
- [Unaccusative with null subject]
[Unaccusative with inversion]

Importantly, in contexts where expletive *ba-* need not apply as a rescuer, it *cannot* appear (Ortiz de Urbina, 1989).

(59) ***Expletive ba- unavailable in non-rescuing contexts***

Mikel *ba-dator.
Mikel FOC-come
'Mikel is COMING./'Mikel IS coming.'

Two kinds of non-expletive elements to the left of a finite V do not qualify as first-position elements: hanging topics and a class of preverbal particles (Etxepare, 2010; Monforte, 2020).

(60) ***Hanging topics are illicit first position elements***

*Mikel, dator?
Mikel, come
'As for Mikel, he's coming/they're coming.'

(61) ***Particles are illicit first position elements***

- a. *(Mikel/Ba) **omen** dator.
Mikel/EXPL EVID comes
'Mikel/he/she/it/they_{sg} supposedly comes.'
- b. *(Mikel/Ba) **al** dator?
Mikel/EXPL Q comes
'Is Mikel/he/she/it/they_{sg} coming?'
- c. *(Mikel/Ba) **ote** dator?
Mikel/EXPL DUB comes
'Might Mikel/he/she/it/they_{sg} come?'

Finally, there are several contexts in which the constraint in (1) does not apply and verb initial orders are indeed possible: (i) certain embedded clause types and (ii) certain imperative types. An example of the first of these are finite relative clauses, as in (62) (De Rijk, 1972; Elordieta and Haddican, 2018).

(62) ***Verb initial orders in relative clauses***

[datorr-en] ekaitz-a
come-C storm-DEF
'The storm that is coming'

A second environment in which V-initial orders are possible are floor-holding contexts in informal speech in question responses. Here the initial finite form—typically a copula—appears initially followed by a pause and a high tone to hold the floor, maybe while the speaker considers the predicate.

(63) ***Verb initial orders in floor-holding responses***

- A: Zer da “CO₂ kontzentrazio-a”?
 what is CO₂ concentration-DEF
 ‘What is the “CO₂ concentration”?’
 B: Da ... nolabaite-ko neurketa bat
 is ...kind-GEN measurement one
 ‘It’s ... a kind of measurement ...’

A final context in which V-initial orders are possible are imperatives of certain synthetic unaccusative verbs, as in (64) (Elordieta and Haddican, 2018).³

(65) ***Verb initial orders in unaccusative imperatives***

- a. Z-oa-z hemen-dik!
 2SG.ABS-go-ABS.PL here-ABL
 ‘Go from here!/Get out of here!’
 b. Z-a-to-z gu-rekin bai gaztea.
 2SG.ABS-FIN-come-ABS.PL 1PL-with yes youth
 ‘Yes, come with us, young person.’

We have seen that the higher effect is sensitive to clause type and embedding type, reminiscent to some degree of (embedded) root phenomena in Germanic (Wiklund et al., 2009). Let us therefore identify the locus of the EPP feature responsible for the higher constraint to be Force targeted by the highest XP (Holmberg, 2015; Elordieta and Haddican, 2018).

(66) ***The structure of the higher constraint***

[ForceP FORCE_[EPP] [FocusP XP_[Foc] [_{ΣP} NEG/PREDP [FinP Aux ...]]]]

3.2 Unified accounts by Arregi and Nevins (2012) and Kiparsky (2017)

Recall that Arregi and Nevins (2012) take the finite verb form to sit in C. They, then, characterize the higher constraint as in (67).

³Other synthetic imperatives, however, do not admit finite verb-initial orders.

(64) ***Verb initial orders disallowed in other imperatives***

- a. *Z-a-bil-tza hona!
 2SG.ABS-FIN-walk-ABS.PL here-ADL
 ‘Walk over here!’
 b. *D-a-ki-zu erantzun-a!
 EDPL-f-know-2SG.ABS answer-DEF
 ‘Find out the answer.’

- (67) ***CP-Noninitiality***
 $C^{0\max}$ cannot be leftmost within CP.
 (Arregi and Nevins, 2012, 338)

This constraint is stated similarly to (15), repeated here.

- (68) ***T-Noninitiality***
 The terminal T cannot be leftmost within $T^{0\max}$.
 (Arregi and Nevins, 2012, 276)

This suggests a more general condition on edge-related constraints:

- (69) Given an edge constraint C on a 0-level node N regulating the distance of N from the edge of some domain D:
 a. If N is an M-word, then D is the maximal projection of N (XP)
 b. Otherwise, N is a terminal, and D is the maximal 0-level projection of $N^{0\max}$.
 (Arregi and Nevins, 2012, 338)

Kiparsky (2017) proposes that the high and low patterns are cases of a single OT constraint penalizing initiality of T in a given domain, as in (70):

- (70) **NonInitiality:** T^0 is not initial in a constituent that it heads.
 a. Lexical instantiation: T^0 (the auxiliary morpheme) can't be initial in its word.
 b. Syntactic instantiation: T^0 (the auxiliary word) can't be initial in its clause.

A first challenge faced by both of these accounts is that embedding type interacts with the higher constraint but not the lower one.

- (62) ***Verb initial orders in relative clauses***
 [datorr-en] ekaitz-a
 come-C storm-DEF
 'The storm that is coming'

A second challenge for this family of approaches comes from previously discussed fact that a class of particles can intervene between the loci of the two effects—the left edge of the clause and the left edge of the finite verb—suggesting separate nodes subject to separate restrictions.

- (71) ***Particles intervene between the loci of the two constraints***
 Ba omen z-e-tor(r)-en
 EXPL EVID EXPL-FIN-COME-PST
 'He/she/it/they_{SG} supposedly was coming.'

3.3 Feature sharing via agreement

Let us summarize some properties observed of the two constraints.

From the perspective of Table 2, the relationship between the two constraints resembles that between second position effects on “T” (subject EPP effects) and “C” (V2) in mainland Scandinavian. Biberauer and Roberts (2010) proposed C-T inheritance of an

<i>Higher constraint</i>	<i>Lower constraint</i>
Any XP satisfies	Only DPs satisfy
Sensitive to embedding type	Insensitive to embedding type
No phi agreement	Phi agreement
Relatively high	Just atop inflectional sequence

Table 2: Properties of two second position effects

EPP feature (with copying) for these varieties. A challenge for this view is that while the lower constraint is *never* violated, the higher constraint *can* be violated in some embedding types.

Still, at least two facts support a syntactic relationship between the locus of the two second position effects (Force and Fin). The first is that imperatives can trigger a special expletive in FinP.

- (72) Goi-an **b**-e-go.
 high-on **EXPL**-FIN-COP
 ‘Rest in peace’ (lit.: be on high) [Imperative]

A less direct source of support for Force-Fin agreement is this. If one takes Fin to be the source of participant features in allocutive agreement (Alok and Baker, 2018; Alok, 2020; Alok and Haddican, 2022), then the distribution of allocutivity in some dialects suggests that Fin is conditioned by embedding type, i.e. Force. Specifically, in some dialects, allocutive morphology is not possible in certain embedding type and/or clause types (Rebuschi, 1981; Oyharçabal, 1993; Haddican and Etxeberria, 2022).

- (73) %Uste d-i-a-t [hemen
 think EXPL-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC-1SG.ERG here
 z-e-go-k-ela].
 EXPL-FIN-ROOT-2SG.FAM.MASC-C
 ‘I think it is here.’

In light of the fact that the lower but not the higher effect is always observed, we propose that the EPP effect on Fin is derivationally prior and the higher effect is derived. Specifically, we suggest that the EPP feature is selectively shared with the locus of the higher effect under agreement with Fin (Pesetsky and Torrego, 2007; Coon and Keine, 2021).

- (74) **Fin-Force agreement**
 [Force_[EPP] [NEG/EVID/EPIST [Fin_[EPP]]]]

4 Conclusion

Two main claims:

- i. The lower constraint is an ordinary syntactic EPP effect—one requiring no post-syntactic structure-building operations.
- ii. The two second position effects resemble those on “T” (subject EPP effects) and “C” (V2) in Mainland Scandinavian. Unlike in Biberauer and Roberts’s (2010)

model, we propose that the higher effect is derived.

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